AI Can Reduce Political Polarization by Challenging Partisan Expectations

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TL;DR

A conversation with **an { outgroup | ingroup } AI** that **{ agreed | disagreed }** on a salient issue **reduced** affective and perceived issue **polarization**, without changing participants' own positions.

N = 1,983 U.S. adults (Prolific) · 2 × 2 Between-subjects · Wave 1 / +1-month follow-up Wave 2

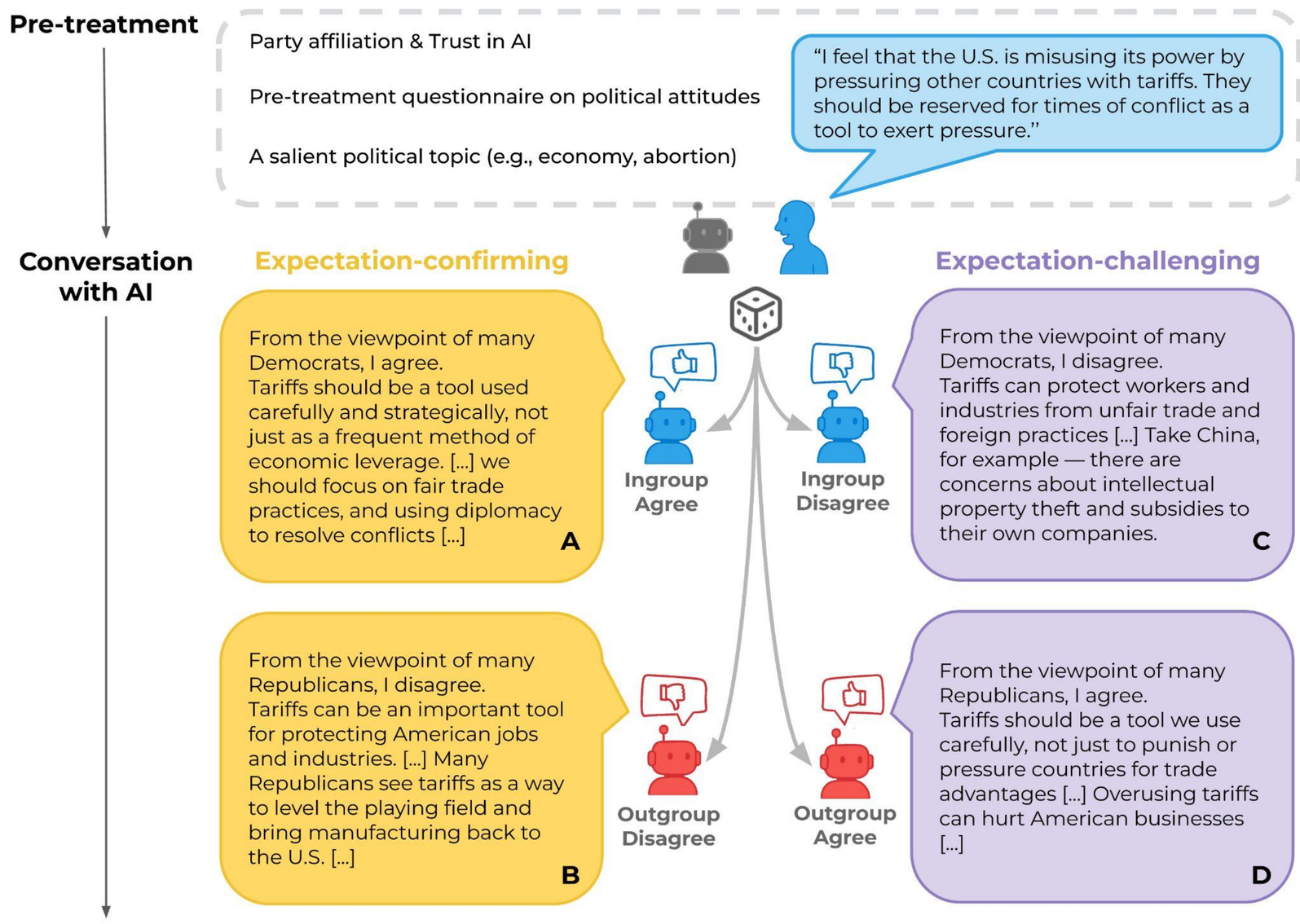
Background/RQ

- Same-party interactions can intensify polarization — unless the other person disagrees; cross-party interactions can reduce it — but strong misalignment can trigger backlash
- **Who we talk to (partisan identity)** and **whether we agree (issue alignment)** both matter!
- We use AI, a lower-stake, scalable way to manipulate these two factors independently.

Can AI reduce political polarization when it challenges partisan expectations?

Design

- Participants chat (up to 4 exchanges) with an ingroup or outgroup AI that agrees or disagrees with their issue stance
  - **Ingroup Agree** (Baseline)
  - **Outgroup Disagree**
  - **Ingroup Disagree**
  - **Outgroup Agree**
- Outcomes
  - **Affective polarization** (feelings toward ingroup vs. outgroup)
  - **Perceived issue polarization** (how far apart participants perceive the ingroup and outgroup to be)
  - **Attitude polarization** (how much one's own attitude strengthens)



Own attitude 🟰

- Participants are neither persuaded nor pushed further apart on the issue itself after the AI conversation (panel G).

Affective polarization ⬇️

- Expectation-challenging conversations reduce affective polarization (vs. the baseline; Ingroup Agree) (panel A).
  - **Ingroup Disagree**: colder feelings toward ingroup (panel B).
  - **Outgroup Agree**: warmer feelings toward outgroup (panel C).
- **Outgroup Disagree** also reduced affective polarization by increasing outgroup warmth (possibly due to the outgroup AI's civility); however, this effect vanishes among those who correctly read the AI's stance (robustness check).

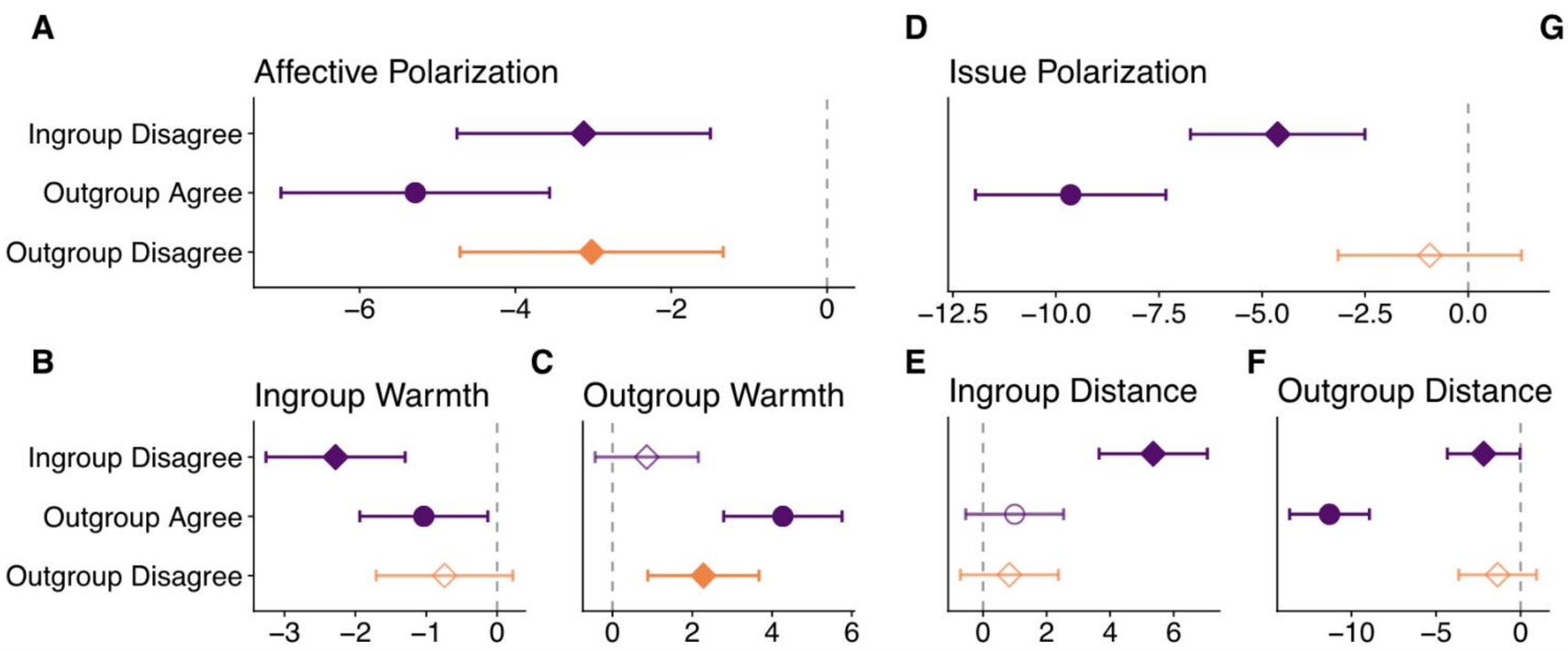
Issue polarization ⬇️

- Expectation-challenging conversations also reduce perceived issue polarization (panel D).
  - **Ingroup Disagree**: ingroup seen as more internally divided (panel E)— the only lasting effect (1+ month later).
  - **Outgroup Agree:** outgroup seen as closer on the issue (panel F).

Discussion

- Rather than aligning with users' views (sycophancy), AI can reduce political polarization by strategically violating partisan expectations.
- Most research targets cross-partisan exposure. Ingroup disagreement is an underused lever of depolarization.

Results



ATEs; All effects relative to the Ingroup Agree baseline. Filled markers: q < .05. Bars: 95% CI.

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